

An active rook can save a weak ending

Endgame Technique

THE IDEA

Passive defense lets the stronger side improve without resistance. An active rook can check the king, attack pawns, and force concessions even while down material. Activity must still respect mating threats and the safety of essential pawns.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A rook tied to defending a pawn from the side may have no counterplay. Sacrificing that pawn to reach the seventh rank can sometimes create enough checks and pawn threats to hold the ending.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

How should you evaluate a pawn sacrifice for rook activity?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Compare the resulting checking opportunities and pawn targets with the passive position's long-term prospects. Do not assume activity compensates; identify the concrete defensive resources.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Seek counterplay that gives the opponent decisions to solve.